Cruising with Craft to the Ends of the Worlds: Practices of shattering, becoming scyborg and dancing with dragons as possible cartographies matt lambert, (Shattering Novella) ISBN 978-91-85549-73-3 Series: Konstfack Dissertation Collection 11

matt lambert and Carl Olof Berg
Livrustkammaren – The Royal Armoury
Stockholm, Sweden
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Photography–Jennifer Drotz Ruhn

S P I T

by and with matt lambert (1989)
and Carl Olof Berg (1975).

SPIT is a collaborative project that originates between Carl Olof Berg and matt lambert.
It also draws in the skills of Jennifer Drotz Ruhn as photographer/videographer, Bernt Karsten Sannerud for audio/sound and Phia Hokkanen for performance garments.

The project SPIT investigates the body as primary location and its performativity in relationship to the institution and the studio. It uses both Livrustkammaren (The Royal Armoury) and SITE in Farsta, both based in Stockholm, Sweden to develop as a project. Just as spit is complex, so has the process of producing SPIT been. The mixture of many creatives' minds from different fields of practice navigating two locations creates a rich and complex dialogue that further enriches SPIT as a project.

SPIT now operates as an investigation between Carl Olof Berg and matt lambert. The project is intentionally designed to mutate. Using photographic images, film, sound, wearable objects, and live performance. SPIT looks at the relationship of saliva to the researchers body and how they have and can exist through archive, document, choreography, object and time. SPIT as a work is a chimera that can be taken in part to respond to specific space or be shown in totality of its physical parts. This methodological approach is blurry and queer, using assemblage to question what exactly the work is.

Spit as a substance holds connotations spanning from care to violence, from sexuality to contagion, from DNA to disgust. It's position of power is both dominant and submissive while simultaneously has capacity to signal mutual love and affection. A necessary fluid that the body regulates, it can also be seen expelled from the body in public space.

The act of spitting is often attached to a masculine gesture often seen mimicked in movies and television. It is the man who walks to the end of the tram platform and projects saliva, the spit hitting a victim's face while they're bashed. Saliva drips from an emoji's mouth on our smartphones signaling want, deliciousness, and even lust. Spit travels between orifices of an open mouth kiss. But, more recently, it is the substance of utmost avoidance for it carries COVID19. Once the project started the visible gestures which accompany spit became more pronounced in everyday life.

The objects in SPIT explore the facets and complexity of spit as a substance, a fluid that is delicate yet sharp, a representation of indulgence and opulence that at times keep people away and at others joins them together. The representations and manifestations of spit are made by hand or through the recording of Berg and lamberts own saliva. Each object representation is through a language of craft using materials that come from sport and the decorative arts.

SPIT was developed pre-pandemic in 2019, so now we had to grapple with the additional complexity of saliva. Saliva is discussed constantly in the news as the main transmitter, a part of someone's body connecting to another. At the same time institutions have had to grapple with the use of saliva in delicate restoration as it is a frequently used substance for its gentle enzymes that help clean and restore antiquities. This led us to discussing what is the representation of spit and when is the substance itself necessary.

As Berg and lambert see it, the work is in the interaction with the spectator. The viewer becomes another piece of the work making it ever evolving. This method is intentionally uncertain and opens itself up to more interpretation. This interpretation also becomes significant as the many gestures of spit as a fluid can be interpreted in many ways at the same time by different people.

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